

Post Purchase Psychology:
Motivators and Barriers to

Upcycling

among Gen Z

Tutorial



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1. Introduction

The modern fashion industry, which is the traditional linear "take-make-dispose" model, is a significant contributor to global pollution, accounting for 8-10% of the world's CO2 emissions (Ofori et al., 2025). This unsustainable system results in immense economic and environmental waste, with billions of dollars lost annually due to underused or discarded clothing. In response, the Circular Economy (CE) has emerged as a crucial alternative (Priyadharshini et al., 2024), proposing a regenerative system where materials are kept in circulation or a loop for as long as possible (Giorgia, 2021). Within the CE framework, upcycling is the process of transforming discarded materials into new products of higher quality or value. It is seen as a promising strategy for reducing waste and conserving resources (Hartanti, Wianto, 2023).

Despite a growing interest in sustainable fashion among Generation Z, a significant "attitude-behaviour gap" persists, where many consumers hold positive attitudes toward sustainability but fail to translate them into action (ARIAH VALDERRAMA, 2023). This creates a "sustainability paradox," where environmental awareness coexists with rampant fast-fashion consumption and scepticism towards greenwashing. The existing academic literature has primarily focused on consumers' purchase intentions for pre-made upcycled goods, leaving a critical research gap: there is limited understanding of the psychological, cultural, and practical factors that motivate or prevent Gen Z from actively upcycling their post-purchase garments (Korhonen et al., 2018). Furthermore, the powerful role of social media in shaping these behaviours remains largely unexplored (ARIAH VALDERRAMA, 2023).



Fig4

This dissertation aims to fill this gap through a qualitative research into the post-purchase psychology of Generation Z. By conducting semi-structured interviews with both active upcyclers and non-upcyclers, this study has three primary objectives:

- 1) to explore how creativity, sustainability values, and personal style influence upcycling decisions;
 - 2) to understand the influence of cultural norms and social media; and
 - 3) to identify the key motivators and barriers that distinguish sustainable intention from action.
- Ultimately, this paper aims to generate deep and actionable insights for fashion brands and other stakeholders to help bridge the intention-action gap and make consumer upcycling a mainstream practice.

2. Literature Review

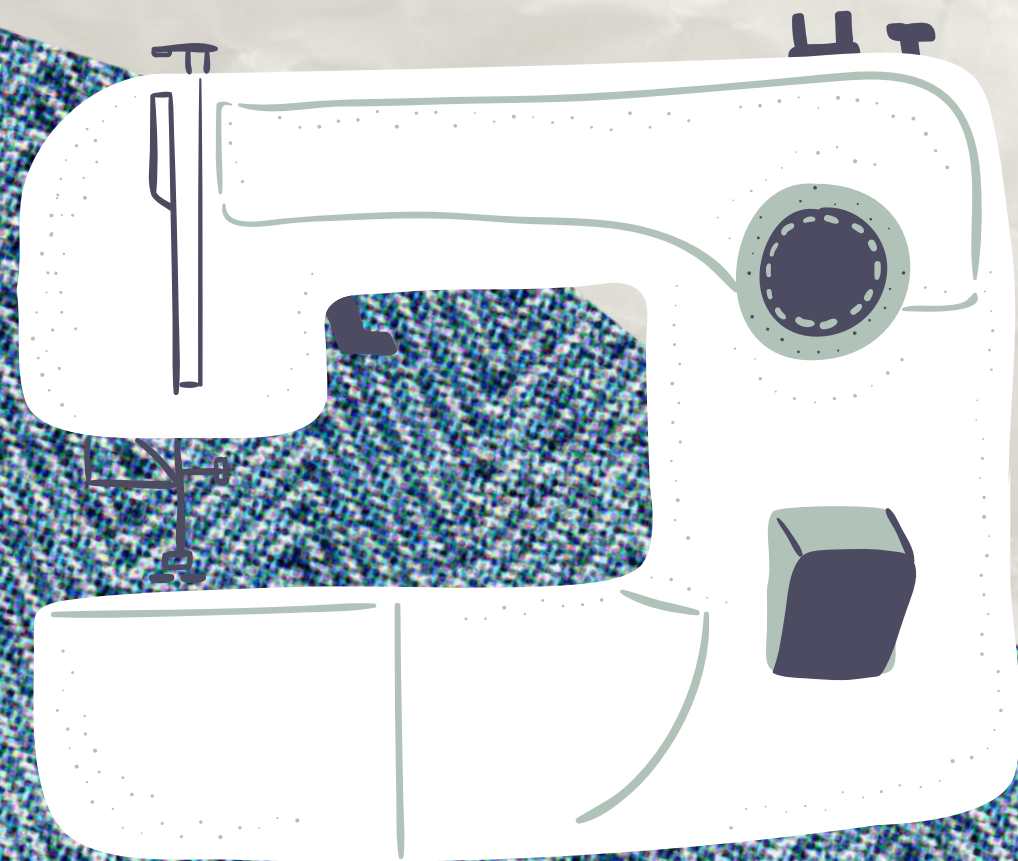


Fig 5

2.1 Circular Economy and the Rise of Upcycling

The current fashion system has caused fashion instability, as it relies on the linear "take-make-dispose" model (Ki et al. 2020). It is widely criticised as extremely harmful and polluting. It has been consistently highlighted in different research that there is a high volume of textile waste generated annually. For instance, the textile and garment industry in Bangladesh reportedly produces over 577,000 tonnes of waste annually, with half of that being recyclable cotton (Akter et al. 2022). A World Bank study predicted a 70% increase in municipal solid trash globally by 2025, from 1.3 billion to 2.2 billion tonnes annually (Yalcin-Enis et al. 2019; Ofori et al. 2025). Alarmingly, only about 25% of discarded clothing is recycled or reused, with the rest heading to landfills (Juanga-Labayen et al. 2022).

The problems generated by fashion's traditional linear model are framed through various interconnected lenses:

- **Environmental Impact:** Often called the world's second-largest polluter (Escourido-Calvo et al. 2025), the industry contributes 8-10% of global CO₂ emissions (Hellstrom, Olsson 2024). Resource depletion is rampant, with one pair of jeans requiring 68 litres of water (Pandit et al. 2020). Toxic chemical discharge also pollutes water sources (Pandit et al. 2020).
- **Economic Waste:** The traditional linear model loses hundreds of billions of dollars annually on underused clothes and \$500 billion a year from overproduction and waste (Ellen MacArthur foundation 2017; The Institute of Positive Fashion 2021)
- **Social Issues:** Production often involves unethical labour conditions like, the 2013 Rana Plaza factory collapse (Cai, Choi 2020). Public outrage is growing, with protestors demanding that "beautiful fashion should not cost the Earth" (Ofori et al. 2025).

The consumer's demand for fast and cheap trends fuels this unhealthy cycle. Fast fashion meets consumer demand at a low cost, and consumers view low-cost clothing as "almost disposable," which encourages purchase impulse and waste production (Pandit et al. 2020). This system seems to generate profit more than sustainability or customer needs (Ritch, Siddiqui 2023). In response to the failures, we need a significant, sustainable alternative, the Circular Economy (CE). First described in 1976 by Stahel and Reday as an "economy of loops", CE is where materials never go waste and nature is regenerated by being in circulation through processes like maintenance, reuse, refurbishment, remanufacture, recycle, and composting (Pandit et al. 2020). This transition aligns with UN Sustainable Development Goals, especially SDG 9 (sustainable industry) and SDG 12 (responsible consumption) (Ofori et al. 2025).

Its core principles revolve around:

- Eliminating waste and pollution (Ritch, Siddiqui 2023)
- Keeping products and materials in use (Ritch, Siddiqui 2023)
- Regenerating the natural capital (Rejeb et al. 2022)

One of the sustainable alternatives under the umbrella of CE is upcycling, a process that turns discarded materials into new products that have higher quality, value, or functionality (Hartanti, Wianto 2023; Durmusoglu, B. Selin Gokkut 2024). In the fashion scenario, upcycling is increasingly seen as a promising strategy for sustainability (Ofori et al. 2025). It gives a new perspective to the value of the clothing item. It redefines and elevates the value of clothing items by transforming discarded materials into products of higher quality, functionality, or aesthetic appeal (Ofori et al. 2025). Upcycling generally consumes less energy and requires fewer additional natural resources compared to recycling processes (Sung et al. 2020).

The benefits of upcycling involve environmental, economic, and socio-psychological advantages:

- Waste Reduction and Resource Conservation: Upcycling reduces waste and conserves raw materials needed for new products (Hanadhyas, Wulandari 2022)
- Reduced Environmental Impact: This practice helps decrease energy consumption, leading to beneficial environmental impacts (Sung et al. 2020)
- Economic Opportunities: Upcycling offers economic savings and creates new profit opportunities by adding aesthetic value and uniqueness to existing products (Bhatt et al. 2018)
- Sociocultural and Psychological Benefits: Engaging in upcycling can provide intrinsic enjoyment, environmental benefits, and aesthetic appeal, encouraging a sense of community creative expression and uniqueness (Ofori et al. 2025; Sung et al. 2019)

Fig 6

In this context, we are talking about consumer upcycling where individuals give old clothes a new life, either by transforming themselves or collaborating with tailors or local makers. It is a trend that blends creativity and sustainability, turning into something fresh, functional, and personally meaningful (Matthews, 2024).

People approach it in different ways:

1. Small changes – like adding new details, adjusting the fit, or tweaking the style to match current trends or personal taste. The garment stays recognisable, but feels new again.
2. Complete transformations – where clothes are repurposed into completely new items, like turning an old shirt into a tote bag or a mens shirt into a child's skirt.

This push towards upcycling is driven by growing consumer awareness and the demand for sustainable options among Gen Z (ARIAH VALDERRAMA 2023). Generation Z (Gen Z) are actively seeking innovative and sustainable fashion options, including upcycling. They are someone who likes to keep it straight and knows what they want. A significant portion of Gen Z (68%) reportedly consumes eco-friendly products, and this generation is expected to have a major share of the market (ARIAH VALDERRAMA 2023). They are more concerned for environmental issues than those of previous generations (Manley et al. 2023).

While consumer behaviour is crucial and many scholars champion upcycling as a key solution, industries must also transform their linear models because it places the burden of sustainability solely on the consumer. Despite increasing consumer interest, research notes a "lack of scalable CF [Circular Fashion] research" and that fashion businesses cannot achieve true sustainability "without customers' commitment to share the moral responsibility for creating sustainability" (Ki et al. 2020; Hellstrom, Olsson 2024). The research on both CE and upcycling is still growing, but studies specifically on consumer upcycling (i.e., self-production of upcycled items or through others) are less common and also less seen compared to research on consumers' purchase intention or motivations for buying upcycled products (Hanadhyas, Wulandari 2022; Shi et al. 2024). This growing trend needs to be researched more in depth for sustainable growth. Upcycling has surfaced as a potential solution, paving the way for further studies in the fashion industry.

2.2 Motivators and Barriers to Upcycling

One of the growing fashion sustainability trends is upcycling. It has been implemented within the fashion industry in recent years and is becoming increasingly popular among Gen Z, who seek innovation and sustainability (ARIAH VALDERRAMA 2023; Hanadhyas, Wulandari 2022). Its widespread adoption, however, is influenced by a complex interplay of intrinsic and extrinsic motivations, along with a range of persistent barriers (Ofori et al. 2025; ARIAH VALDERRAMA 2023). Therefore, a thorough understanding of these motivators and barriers is essential for knowing what to encourage to promote upcycling practices and foster greater engagement in this sustainable endeavour.

Intrinsic motivations are self-determined and powerful forces supporting upcycling behaviour (Shi et al. 2024). Research shows perceived competence as the strongest internal driver, which is the satisfaction an individual gains from learning new skills (e.g., sewing, painting) and creatively solving problems during the transformation process (Shi et al. 2024). This makes an individual feel empowered. Empowerment fuels a sense of autonomy from mass consumption norms, led by the values of protecting the environment (Dwikesumasari et al. 2024). All this intrinsic enjoyment enhances one's creative thinking, challenges consumers to devise novel uses for items, and necessitates learning about material properties and refining crafting skills like sewing or painting (Shi et al. 2024). Upcycling introduces individuals to the joy of self-expression through customisation and liberates them from the traditional linear methods. Personal values are also central, where a strong sense of waste prevention, reflecting a desire to minimise resource use, is a key motivator for both creating and purchasing upcycled products (Shi et al. 2024). This leads to avoiding new expenditures, a motivating factor to reclaim value from discarded items (Shi et al. 2024). For humans, things hold memories and also create new ones. Emotional attachment motivates giving new life to cherished items. It also fosters social connectedness through knowledge-sharing in communities and satisfies a desire for social approval and a sense of purpose (Shi et al. 2024). This fosters a sense of belonging to a community that actively challenges the linear consumption model and champions sustainable practices.



Fig8

Despite strong motivations, significant barriers hinder the adoption of upcycling. While some studies emphasise practical barriers like a lack of skills or tools, other research suggests that for a socially-conscious demographic like Gen Z, psychological barriers such as the fear of social disapproval may be an even more significant deterrent (Shi et al. 2024). A persistent stigma exists against old or upcycled clothes, as they are sometimes considered low-quality or unhygienic (van Hees et al. 2024). The fear of social disapproval over a "tacky" or worn aesthetic also acts as a deterrent. These stigmas can also be generated from a lack of awareness around upcycling and its value among consumer. This is caused by public scepticism toward environmental claims, often fueled by corporate greenwashing (Ofori et al. 2025). This lack of clear information creates market uncertainty that hinders both production and purchasing (Manley et al. 2023). Understanding which of these barrier types presents the greater obstacle is crucial.

According to research, complexities create gaps between intention and action. The attitude-behaviour gap is because many Gen Z hold positive attitudes toward upcycling but fail to act on them (Gurova 2024; ARIAH VALDERRAMA 2023). A significant contradiction exists between Gen Z's environmental awareness and their continued preference for fast fashion. This is further complicated by a "sustainability paradox," where they question the true impact of their sustainable choices, grapple with issues of overconsumption, and exhibit scepticism towards "greenwashing," ultimately hindering widespread upcycling adoption (Escourido-Calvo et al. 2025). Therefore, this dissertation aims to qualitatively investigate how Gen Z consumers navigate this 'sustainability paradox.' By exploring their lived experiences, this research seeks to identify the specific triggers that can successfully bridge the gap between their sustainable intentions and their active participation in upcycling.



Fig 9

2.3 Theoretical Framework: Understanding Upcycling Intentions and Behaviours



Fig10

The Theory of Planned Behaviour (TPB) (Bosnjak et al. 2020) provides a strong framework for understanding and predicting individual behaviours. The model is based on the construct of behavioural intention, a strong predictor of actual behaviour. This intention is shaped by three core determinants: Attitude toward the Behaviour, Subjective Norms, and Perceived Behavioural Control (PBC). The relationship can be summarised as:

Attitude + Subjective Norms + PBC → Intention → Behaviour

1. Attitude toward the Behaviour

Attitude shows an individual's positive or negative evaluation of engaging in a specific behaviour (Bosnjak et al. 2020). In the context of upcycling, attitudes are influenced by perceptions of creativity, sustainability, and enjoyment (Wijekoon et al. 2025). Existing research indicates that Generation Z generally demonstrates favourable attitudes toward upcycled products (Wijekoon et al. 2025). However, negative perceptions such as doubts regarding quality can avoid this engagement (Wagner, Heinzl 2020). This can also mean that it can enhance their likelihood of engagement in circular fashion practices like upcycling. Also, influencers showcasing creative upcycled outfits could foster positive attitudes (Shi et al. 2024). Attitudes are shaped by underlying beliefs, emotional responses, and behavioural intentions towards circular fashion models (Bosnjak et al. 2020).

2. Subjective Norms

Subjective norms refer to perceived social pressure from significant others, such as family, friends, and peers, to perform or avoid a given behaviour (Bosnjak et al. 2020). Within upcycling, these norms influence whether an individual perceives social approval for engaging in upcycling and such approval can strengthen intention. Viral trends and community hashtags (e.g., #upcyclefashion) create powerful social pressure (ARIAH VALDERRAMA 2023). Whereas in some cultural contexts, social status is associated with purchasing new goods, causing upcycling to be stigmatised as indicative of lower status (van Hees et al. 2024).

3. Perceived Behavioural Control (PBC)

PBC means an individual's perception of the ease or difficulty of performing a behaviour, shaped by both self-efficacy and perceived external barriers (Bosnjak et al. 2020). In the case of upcycling, low PBC resulting from limited skills, time, resources, or space may suppress behavioural intentions even when attitudes are positive (Shi et al. 2024). Also, the availability of video tutorials on platforms like TikTok and Instagram can increase a user's confidence in their own skills (self-efficacy), directly impacting PBC (Shi et al. 2024). Conversely, high self-confidence in one's ability to upcycle can mitigate these barriers.

The TPB has been extensively applied to studies on sustainable consumer behaviour, especially with upcycled products and is particularly effective in examining the attitude-behaviour gap, where positive intentions fail to translate into action (Bosnjak et al. 2020). This theory fits really well with upcycling. Deciding to upcycle is both about being trendy and a thoughtful choice, given that one of the core values of Gen Z is sustainability (Durmusoglu, B. Selin Gokkut 2024). We've already seen TPB work in similar areas, too. For example, a study by Kaffashi et al. (2023) used TPB to look at how Gen Z in Malaysia decides whether to buy upcycled clothes, showing that the theory can capture the mindset of this generation when it comes to sustainability. Similarly, Lee et al. (2023) investigated Gen Z's purchase intentions for upcycled products, using TPB to determine influential factors. These studies show that the Theory of Planned Behaviour (TPB) is a helpful tool for breaking down the complex factors behind why Gen Z engages in upcycling. In other words, TPB gives us a roadmap for unpacking the mix of personal values, social pressures, and practical considerations that shape Gen Z's upcycling habits. Basically an in-depth insight. It offers a clear way to explore what motivates them and what holds them back, leading to a deeper understanding of Gen Z's around upcycling their clothes after buying them.

Research Gap

Existing academic literature on upcycling predominantly addresses the supply-side (production) within the broader context of the circular economy, often neglecting the consumption-side perspective. Although some research has largely centred on consumers' purchase intentions towards upcycled goods, with limited exploration of active or consumer upcycling where individuals modify their own garments, either personally or through third-party services (Shi et al. 2024).

The consumer role is often conceptualised as passive or strictly rational, with insufficient attention to the psychological, cultural, and creative drivers behind upcycling engagement (Shi et al. 2024). Also, there is a growing trend of upcycling among Generation Z, prominently visible on social media platforms where individuals share and showcase their upcycled garments (Muhammad Nawaz Tunio 2024; ARIAH VALDERRAMA 2023). This digital visibility not only reflects rising interest but also positions social media as a potential driver of engagement in upcycling practices. Furthermore, much of the research on eco-fashion and upcycling has been conducted within narrow demographic segments, such as fashion design students, limiting the generalisability of findings.

Identified Gap: There is a lack of empirical research examining the post-purchase psychology of Generation Z consumers in relation to consumer upcycling. While interest in sustainable and circular fashion practices is increasing, actual engagement in upcycling remains developing.

Understanding the motivators, barriers, and post-purchase psychology associated with upcycling among Generation Z can provide valuable insights for marketers and policymakers, enabling them to design targeted campaigns and informed policies that encourage upcycling among Gen Z for a sustainable future for the fashion industry. These insights form the basis for the present study's **research questions**,

1. How do creativity, sustainability values, and personal style influence Generation Z's decisions to upcycle clothing?
2. How do cultural norms and social media influence Generation Z's perceptions and practices of upcycling?
3. What are the key motivators and barriers affecting Generation Z's upcycling behaviour, and how do these factors influence their decision-making process?

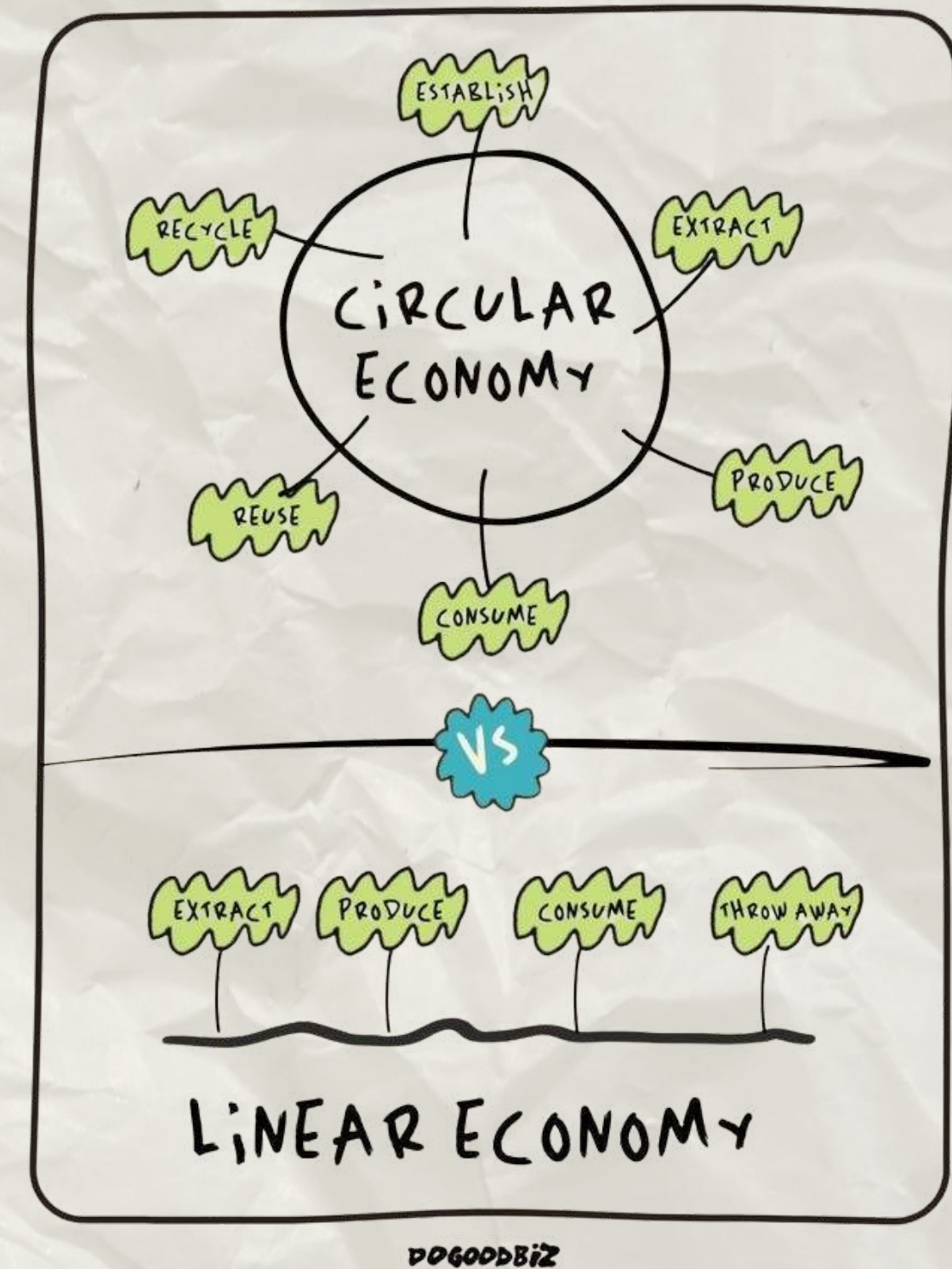


Fig 11

2.4 Influence of culture and social media

Cultural norms and values exert a significant influence on how people feel about keeping clothes for upcycling. In some cultures, thriftiness and resourcefulness are seen as virtues, so upcycling feels like a natural extension of those traditions (Shi et al., 2024). But in other places, especially in societies where social status is tied to buying new or luxury items, upcycling can carry a stigma, as a sign of lower status or lack of wealth (Singh, Giacosa, 2018). Consumerism pushes the idea that new is always better, even though there's a growing interest in giving clothes a longer life (Niinimäki, Armstrong 2013).

Apart from the stigma, broader cultural shifts such as the sustainability movement, fast fashion trends, and the rise of the creator economy have reframed upcycling from a niche craft to a culturally significant practice (Shi et al., 2024; Sung et al. 2019). Growing awareness of environmental challenges among Gen Z has made some of them try upcycling while reducing waste, and contributing to personal and collective well-being (Manley et al. 2023). The instability related to it has enhanced the appeal of upcycled products, allowing individuals to express personal identity through customised pieces.

The rise of the creator economy has made upcycling practices to flourish. Accessible physical spaces (e.g., Makerspaces, Hackspaces) and digital marketplaces (e.g., Etsy, Folksy) have enabled individuals to transform discarded textiles into marketable products, fostering entrepreneurship and skill development (ARIAH VALDERRAMA 2023; Sung et al. 2019). In this context, upcycling is not only a form of creative expression but also a potential economic opportunity, capable of generating income and providing employment.



Fig12

Fig13



Fig 14

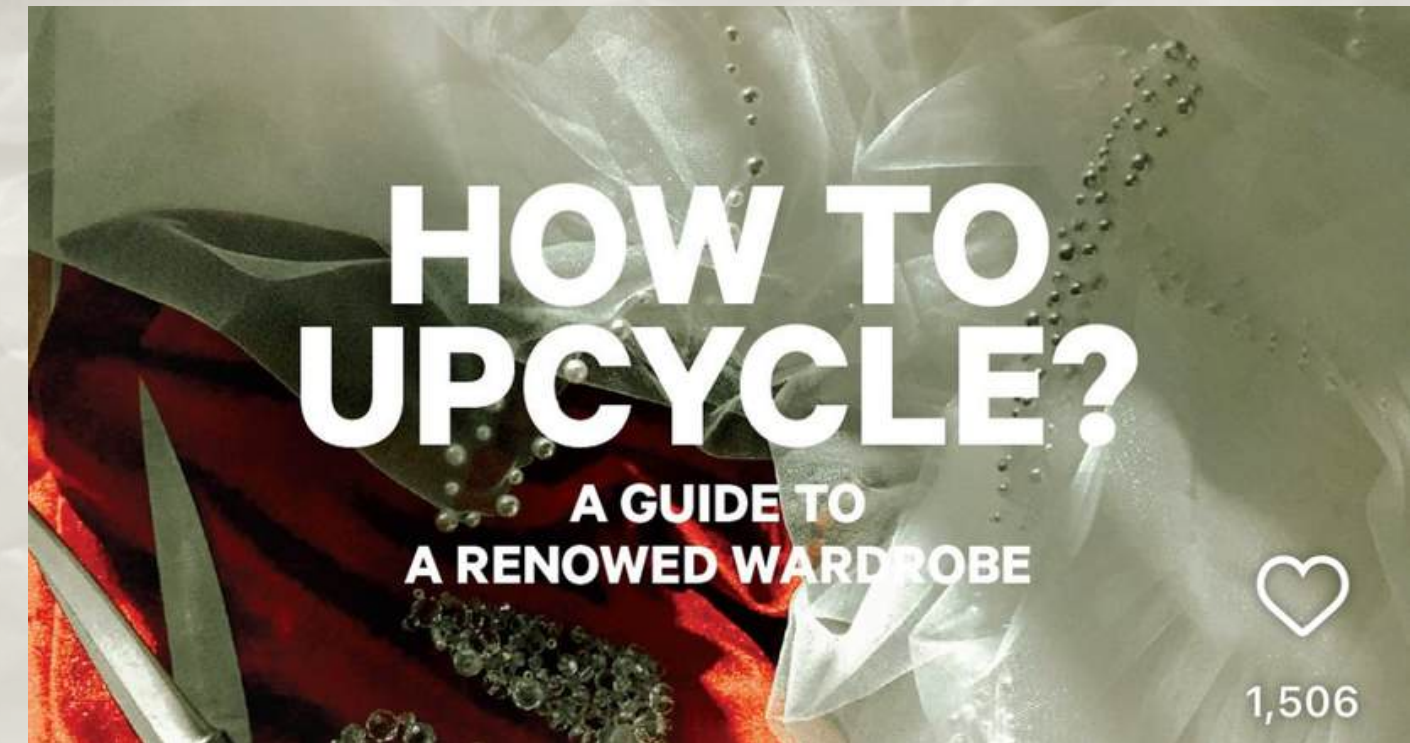


Fig 15

A significant portion of Gen Z (68%) reportedly consumes eco-friendly products, and this generation is projected to constitute a substantial share of the market (ARIAH VALDERRAMA, 2023; Pandit et al. 2020). For Generation Z, social media has become a powerful tool for challenging old norms (ARIAH VALDERRAMA, 2023). Platforms like Instagram and TikTok have turned into hubs of inspiration, where fashion content creators showcase upcycling ideas and make them feel exciting and fresh. Tutorials, DIY hacks, and real-life examples help young people see how upcycling can be a form of self-expression and creativity, not just a way to save money. These platforms create a sense of community, making this movement feel more authentic and achievable (ARIAH VALDERRAMA, 2023).

These user-generated content, such as posting upcycled creations helps to normalise the behaviour, while online groups dedicated to upcycling encourage collaborative learning, the exchange of skills and strengthens collective identity (ARIAH VALDERRAMA, 2023; Shi et al., 2024). Also, sharing positive emotions derived from upcycling experiences can inspire others, particularly within peer-driven digital networks.

Social media addresses informational barriers by providing constant exposure to creative ideas, techniques, and success stories, thereby increasing perceived behavioural control (Shi et al., 2024). For businesses, social media serves as an effective marketing channel to engage younger audiences, particularly Gen Z, who show high levels of interaction with sustainable content (ARIAH VALDERRAMA, 2023).

Understanding cultural norms and social media influence is essential for comprehending Generation Z's attitudes and behaviours toward upcycling. Cultural values shape the baseline perceptions of the practice, while social media acts as a catalyst that reframes it as aspirational, creative, and socially validated.

2.5 Marketing Upcycling

Marketing strategies can close the gap between what Gen Z says they want to do (sustainable consumption) and what they actually do by promoting upcycling while strategically shaping consumer attitudes, leveraging social and cultural norms, and enhancing perceived control over the practice.

To shape Gen Z consumer attitudes, marketing can employ storytelling to show the transformative process of upcycling (Shi et al. 2024). It would highlight the “journey” of a discarded item, emphasising its past, the craftsmanship involved in its renewal, and the environmental benefits. It can elicit emotional connections, uniqueness, self-expression, and individuality, countering negative perceptions associated with second-hand materials.

Influencers and content creators on social media platforms are crucial for leveraging social norms as they are also trendsetters (Gurova 2024; Ritch, Siddiqui 2023). Some of them who promote upcycling can empower consumers to do it and reduce perceived barriers to it. These efforts not only increase visibility but also create a sense of belonging and reduce the knowledge gap among participants.

Research also showcases that premium branding and high-quality design are essential for removing the stigma of second-hand goods and justifying higher price points (van Hees et al. 2024; Machado et al. 2019). Transparent communication and awareness for upcycling by the brands can build trust and convey authenticity about the process (Wijekoon et al. 2025). Certifications and quality assurances further legitimise the product, while highlighting the individuality of each piece, which reinforces exclusivity and artisan value.

When it comes to communication, brands should focus on educating consumers about what makes upcycling different and exciting which can help build trust and change any negative perceptions about quality or authenticity (Marques et al., 2019). It also places the brands to position themselves as sustainable and caring for the environment. This educational approach directly enhances Perceived Behavioural Control (PBC) by giving consumers the confidence and knowledge they need to participate.

Gen Z highly values creativity, personalisation, and the joy of making something unique (ARIAH VALDERRAMA 2023). So, brands have a great opportunity to tap into these motivators by showing how upcycling can be a fun, creative, and deeply personal process



Fig16

3. Methodology

3.1 Introduction

This section outlines the methodological framework designed to investigate the motivators and barriers influencing Generation Z's post-purchase upcycling behaviour. The preceding literature review identified a clear gap in the research, where while consumers' purchase intention for upcycled goods has been studied, there is limited exploration of the psychological and cultural factors that drive active, post-purchase upcycling among Gen Z. This study aims to fill that gap by exploring how creativity, sustainability values, cultural norms, and social media influence Gen Z's decision-making process. To achieve this, this chapter will map out the study's research design and inductive approach. It will then justify the strategy of inquiry, sampling strategy, and data collection and analysis procedures, before concluding this section with a discussion of the study's limitations and ethical considerations.



Fig17



Fig18



Fig19



3.2 Positionality statement

As a Gen Z researcher, it is important to state the researcher's interest in this study. They approach this topic not only as academic but as an active participant in the culture they are investigating. Their interest grew from personal experience; as someone who enjoys following upcycling trends on social media, they have seen how influencers' posts spark motivation and positive conversations online. Their own upcycling projects and collaborations with tailors have given them hands-on insights into both the creativity and the challenges of upcycling. These experiences inspire their research and shape the questions they are asking, aiming to explore what drives Gen Z to upcycle and what might hold them back.

This personal engagement is a strength, offering a nuanced understanding that shapes the research questions and will help in building rapport with participants. However, they recognise that it also introduces potential subjectivity and personal bias. To mitigate this, they will maintain reflexivity throughout the research process. They used a structured and systematic method outlined in this section: semi-structured interviews, adopting QUAGOL framework and thematic analysis, also ensuring their analysis reflects the participants' voices rather than their own assumptions. This would ensure that the findings are both authentic and reliable.

3.3 Research Approach

This study is taking a qualitative ethnographic approach, which is inherently inductive in nature. Ethnography seeks to understand cultural phenomena by observing human interactions to uncover the meaning of a situation, practice, or experience (Quimby, 2006). Because it is inductive, the research begins with these observations instead of testing pre-set hypotheses, where findings emerge directly from the data (Thomas, 2006).

Thomas (2006) describes the General Inductive Approach for studying qualitative data, a method where researchers can develop findings based on data. The approach involves multiple readings of raw data, identifying key themes and categories, and reducing the data to a summary format that reflects the study's evaluation of its objectives.

Since this research topic is still under-explored, particularly with regard to the influence of culture and social media on upcycling habits, this approach is essential. It provides a systematic and flexible method for identifying themes directly from participant responses (Judith Zaccagnini Flynn, Foster 2009, pp.115–223). By focusing on patterns driven by the data itself, without imposing external theories, this methodology will capture authentic insights into how Gen Z consumers perceive and engage in upcycling, creating a clear, practical understanding of the factors that influence them.

3.4 Research Design

This study adopts a qualitative research dology to explore the post-purchase psychological, cultural, and social media factors that influence Gen Z's upcycling behaviours. This approach is apt for this research as it allows for an in-depth investigation into the "why" behind these behaviours, providing rich and detailed insights that quantitative methods might miss (Judith Zaccagnini Flynn, Foster 2009, pp.115–223). This approach ensures that the findings are not only credible but also deeply rooted in the lived experiences of the participants.

The study has combined primary and secondary research. Secondary research consisted of a review of existing literature related to the topic, which helped in the development of the research questions and interview guide.

The analysis of this study is guided by the QUAGOL (Qualitative Analysis Guide of Leuven) framework (Dierckx De Casterlé et al. 2012), a structured and flexible method that provides rigour and transparency to the complex process of qualitative data analysis. It has a two-phase approach. The first phase is a preparatory phase focusing on familiarity with the data and narrative construction, and the second phase is a coding phase for systematic analysis. During the coding and theme development stages, Braun and Clarke's (Yardley 2024) six-phase thematic analysis provided a systematic structure for generating, reviewing, and defining themes, ensuring transparency and rigour. Thematic analysis can be positioned with other qualitative methods that identify themes or patterns, while relating it to various epistemological and ontological perspectives (Braun, Clarke 2013).

3.5 Strategy of Inquiry

The research will use semi-structured interviews to collect qualitative data. This method is chosen as it helps to capture the personal stories, motivations, and perceived barriers related to upcycling, nuances that are often missed by quantitative surveys. Adeoye-Olatunde and Olenik (2021) explore the use of semi-structured interviews as a research method by highlighting their flexibility and effectiveness in getting in-depth qualitative data.

In designing the interview process, I will apply the framework provided by Adeoye-Olatunde and Olenik (2021). Following their guidance, I will develop questions that are structured to ensure consistency across interviews with open-ended prompts that encourage participants to share their unique perspectives. To effectively investigate both the motivations for and barriers to upcycling, the interviews will be tailored to the participant's experience. A distinct set of questions will be used for those who have upcycled, while a different set will be used for those who have never upcycled. While acknowledging that this method can be time-consuming to analyse, the in-depth nature of the data would provide would be valuable for the exploratory nature of this study (Adeoye-Olatunde and Olenik 2021). This rigorous approach will ensure the data collected is both rich and relevant. [For interview questions, see Appendix B]

3.6 Research Methods

3.6.1 Time Horizon

The data for this study were collected using a cross-sectional approach, getting an in-depth view of Gen Z's current upcycling attitudes and practices. This approach is ideal for forming a clear picture of the motivators and barriers that exist among Gen Z at a single point in time. As noted by Wang and Cheng (2020), cross-sectional studies are well-suited for exploratory research as they are quick, cost-effective, and allow for the analysis of various behaviours and conditions within a population.

Given that this study aims to understand trends and influences, such as social media's current role, this time horizon is perfectly aligned with the research goals. While this approach cannot track behavioural changes over time, its strength lies in gathering rich, descriptive data efficiently, making it highly suitable for identifying key themes and providing valuable insights for potential marketing campaigns (Wang, Cheng 2020).

3.6.2 Sampling Strategy

This study employed a purposive sampling strategy to recruit Gen Z participants irrespective of the demographics (Campbell et al. 2020). This technique involved intentionally seeking out two different groups: individuals with direct upcycling experience, and those who are interested in the practice but have not yet tried it. Participants were recruited through posts on university forums and targeted social media groups focused on sustainability and upcycling.

As explained by Campbell et al. (2020), this method is ideal for qualitative research as it gives importance to the depth and relevance of data over statistical representation. While this means the findings will not be generalisable to the entire Gen Z population, this approach is the most effective way to ensure the collected data provides credible and informative insights directly related to the research questions (Campbell et al. 2020).

3.6.3 Data Collection and Analysis

Primary data was collected through semi-structured interviews with Gen Z participants. This method allows for flexible conversations that can explore topics ranging from personal motivations to the role of social media in upcycling. Each interview was audio-recorded and then transcribed verbatim to create a detailed text for analysis. This primary data collection was contextualised by a comprehensive review of existing academic literature sourced from databases like Google Scholar as secondary research.

The transcribed interview data were analysed using a structured qualitative approach. The analysis was done using the Qualitative Analysis Guide of Leuven (QUAGOL) (Dierckx de Casterlé et al. 2012), which provides a robust framework for ensuring a systematic and transparent process. Within this framework, specific stages of coding and theme generation were guided by Braun and Clarke's (2006) influential six-phase approach to thematic analysis.

This combined method provides a rigorous process for identifying and interpreting themes within the data, ensuring the findings are credible and authentically grounded in the participants' own narratives.

3.6.4 Data Validation

To ensure the trustworthiness of the findings, various validation strategies were employed, focusing on enhancing the research's credibility and confirmability. Member checking enabled participants to verify the correctness of their interpretation. Triangulation was achieved by comparing the themes that emerged from the two distinct participant groups (those with upcycling experience and those without). This will help to build a richer, more comprehensive understanding by identifying points of convergence and divergence between their perspectives (Bhandari 2023). A reflexive journal was maintained throughout the research process (Olmos-Vega et al. 2022). This journal was used to document the researcher's personal assumptions, thoughts, and decisions, which helped to identify and mitigate potential researcher bias and ensure the findings are grounded in the data.

3.6.5 Ethical Considerations

The study was conducted in adherence to the highest ethical standards, with formal ethical approval to be obtained from the university before any data collection began [See Appendix A]. Voluntary participation and transparency were important throughout the research process.

All participants were provided with a clear information sheet, and informed consent was secured before each interview, as outlined by Wiles (2013). Participants were explicitly informed of their right to withdraw from the study at any time without consequence. To further protect privacy during the online interviews, participants had the option to keep their cameras turned off..

To ensure anonymity and confidentiality, all personal data was preserved by strict data management (Dooly et al., 2017). The researcher also completed the university's research ethics training module, which underpinned my commitment to responsible and ethical conduct (see Appendix A)

3.6.6 Limitation

This study has limitations. The findings are shaped by the study's specific sample. The use of purposive sampling with a focused sample size of 12 participants (six who have upcycled and six who have not) means the results are not statistically generalisable to all Gen Z consumers. This approach was intentionally chosen to emphasise analytical depth and relevance over statistical breadth (Andrade, 2020). Furthermore, with participants primarily belonging from the UK and India, and only one participant from Taiwan, the findings reflect specific cultural contexts and may not reflect the full diversity of Gen Z attitudes globally. To mitigate this, rich, detailed descriptions of the participant's answers will be provided to help readers analyse the transferability of the findings to similar contexts (See Appendix C)

The study employs a cross-sectional approach, which offers a detailed image of current attitudes but does not track how these behaviours might evolve over time. This approach was deemed the most practical and effective for capturing present-day trends and influences within the scope of this project (Wang & Cheng, 2020).

3.6.7 Conclusion

In summary, this section has given a detailed understanding of the qualitative methodology supporting this study. By applying in-depth, semi-structured interviews, the research explores the key drivers and barriers influencing upcycling behaviours among Gen Z participants. While acknowledging the limitations of this approach, the chosen methodology is designed to develop a nuanced understanding of post-purchase psychology in this context. Ultimately, the aim is to generate valuable insights that can help brands and fellow researchers encourage more sustainable consumer practices.



Fig 20

4. Findings

This section presents the findings from the thematic analysis of twelve semi-structured interviews conducted with Generation Z consumers. In order to explore the motivators, barriers, and socio-cultural factors influencing their engagement with post-purchase fashion upcycling, a combination of the systematic stages of the Qualitative Analysis Guide of Leuven (QUAGOL) (Dierckx De Casterlé et al. 2012) with the widely recognised phases of Braun and Clarke's (2006) thematic analysis was used.

The initial phase of the analysis involved a systematic coding of all twelve transcripts to identify recurring and important themes. The codes generated were then collated into the thematic framework presented in the Findings. A comprehensive table outlining the initial coding process, also including illustrative quotes for each code, can be found in Appendix D

These themes are mentioned below with a critical analysis of the data and supported by verbatim quotes from the participants:

Emotions and Clothing: Legacy, Memory, and Self-Expression

Upcycling, especially for those with experience, is a powerful motivator because garments hold immense emotional value for the. This emotion attached to their piece of clothing outweighs the monetary worth of an item and is rooted in its connection to personal history, family, and identity. Upcycling is framed as an act of preservation, a way to continue the legacy of a loved one by transforming their clothing into a wearable memory.

Participant 1 described wearing their grandmother's upcycled sari as feeling "that energy...I sort of feel the warmth", while Participant 3 felt that wearing a kurta made from their mother's sari made it feel "like my mother is with me".

This perspective showed that upcycled items have a story and a soul attached to them that new, mass-produced clothes inherently lack. Even for non-upcyclers, this concept held significant theoretical value.

Jada identified the primary value of a hypothetical upcycled item as "Sentimental, I guess. Rather than just something that is picked out of the store that anyone could grab".

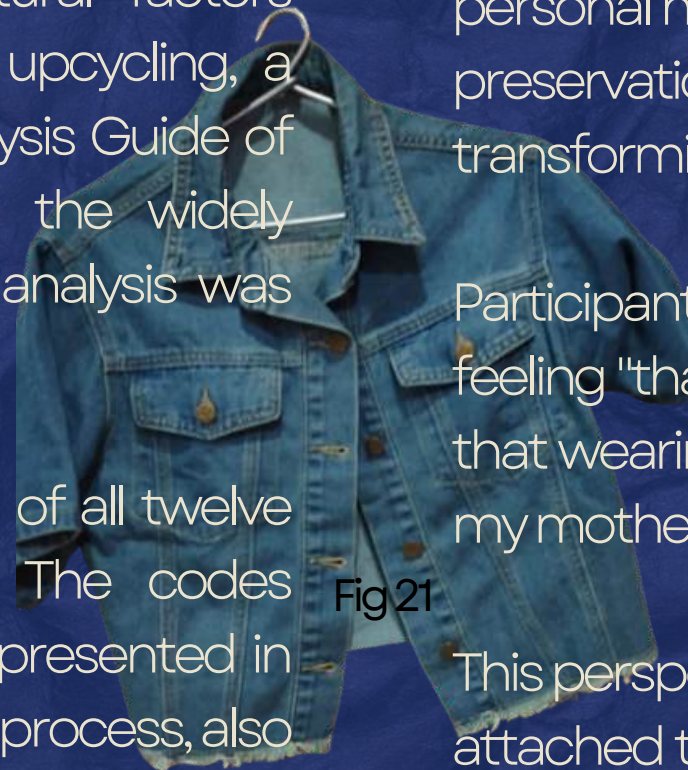


Fig 21

Upcycling Inherited from Cultural

The analysis revealed a distinct cultural dimension where upcycling is not viewed as a new trend but rather as a normalised, intergenerational practice. This was particularly evident among participants with an Indian background, who described resourcefulness as a value learned from childhood, especially from their mothers.

This theme acts as a powerful facilitator. Participants from the upcycler group frequently credited their mothers and grandmothers as their primary teachers.

Participant 6 stated, "Culturally upcycling is something that we Indians have always done. Because we have never promoted waste in our country...In fact, it's very normal for us". Similarly, Participant 1 noted, "this idea was embedded in me since my childhood".

This is in sharp contrast with the experience of Participant 10, a non-upcycler from a different cultural background, who found the concept entirely new because her culture gives importance to owning of new items, stating, "recycle or sustainability, this kind of culture is not a really big issue in my culture".



Fig 22

The Practicality Hurdle: Skills, Time, and Confidence

This theme stated a clear gap between positive intentions and actual behaviour. It showcases three interrelated challenges:

- **Lack of Technical Skill:** Both groups cited a lack of sewing and construction skills as a major barrier. Participant 12, a non-upcycler, felt he didn't "know too much about the clothing and like stitching".
- **Time Constraints:** The Gen Z participants complained about a fast-paced lifestyle as a reason for incompatibility with the time-consuming nature of upcycling. Participant 5 noted, "nowadays everything is just about convenience. Quick, quick, quick trend in trend trends out".
- **Lack of Creative Confidence:** This was particularly prominent among non-upcyclers, who expressed a fear that their efforts would result in a poor-quality or unattractive outcome. Participant 11 stated, "The result. I think that will it even turn out that will the product... What if I construct this piece of clothes more, then I want it?"

Algorithm Dilemma

Social media emerged as a powerful but contradictory force. On one hand, it serves as a source of inspiration and knowledge for making upcycling more accessible and trendy.

Participant 1 was directly inspired by a video to make a tote bag from old jeans, stating, “I decided to cut my jeans and I made a beautiful to bag.” Participant 2 was motivated by an Instagram Reel that showed her the potential in a vintage piece, telling, “...and that made me reconsider...turning one of my garment into something nice because I saw the potential in it.”

However, participants also critically observed that these platforms rampantly promote hyper-consumption. The same algorithms that show a DIY tutorial will immediately follow it with advertisements for fast fashion.

Participant 4 noted, "I see more things which would trigger me to buy new stuff, but very few things which encourage me to upcycle".

This situation creates a “dilemma of algorithms” because platforms simultaneously encourage and undermine sustainable behaviour.

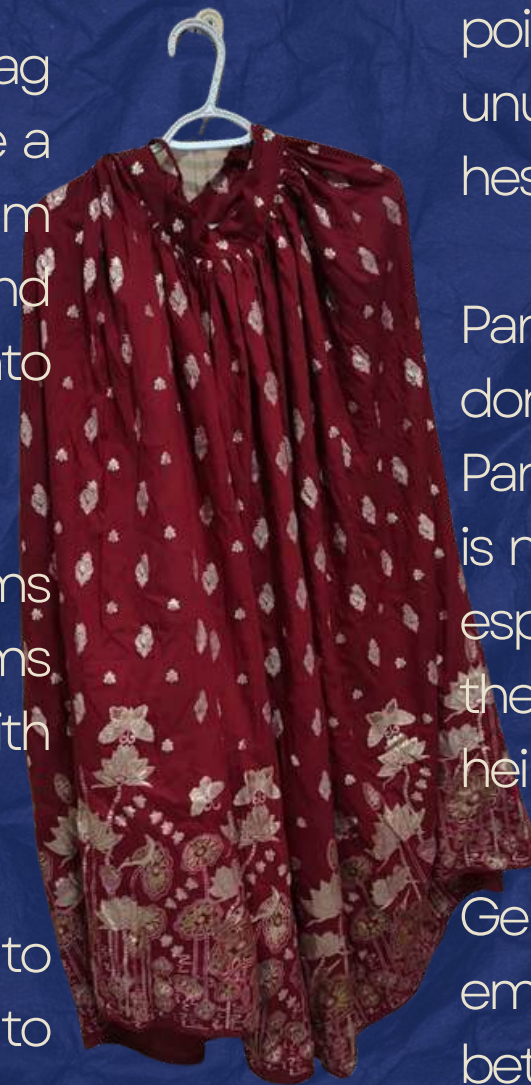


Fig 23

The Anxiety of the First Cut

If we look into the barrier of "lack of confidence," a more specific and strong psychological hurdle was identified, which was the fear of making the first, irreversible cut into a garment. This act shows a point of no return, risking transforming a potentially usable item into unusable waste. This anxiety was a key reason why non-upcyclers hesitate.

Participant 12 explained this perfectly, explaining he would rather donate a piece than "ruin that product" through a failed attempt. Participant 11 also voiced this fear of an unfixable mistake. This anxiety is not only limited to beginners, but also experienced by upcyclers, especially when working with cherished items. Participant 1 noted the fear of "ruining the original garment" if it was a valuable family heirloom.

Gen Z's upcycling behaviour is influenced by an interplay of emotional, cultural, practical, and social factors. Bridging the gap between positive intention and perceived difficulty is crucial for upcycling to become mainstream among Gen Z.

5. Discussion

This section critically analyses the major findings from the semi-structured interviews with 12 Generation Z participants, where six were active upcyclers and the remaining six were non-upcyclers. The aim is to interpret these findings within the context of existing literature and the Theory of Planned Behaviour (TPB), thereby addressing the research questions on the motivators and barriers to consumer upcycling. It will offer insights for fashion brands and other key stakeholders aiming to bridge the gap between sustainable intentions and consumer action by trying to make upcycling mainstream.

This study's qualitative data reveals a detailed and contradictory landscape of Gen Z's relationship with fashion upcycling. While a surface-level commitment to sustainability is present across both upcycler and non-upcycler groups (Manley et al. 2023), the factors that transform this passive awareness into active engagement are multifaceted. This discussion will first critically analyse the distinct worlds of the two groups before moving to a cross-group comparison. This comparative analysis will shed light on the common and, more significantly, the critical points of difference that distinguish between interest and action.

The upcycler group's motivations were predominantly intrinsic, ranging from practical considerations like cost-saving to deep sentimental attachment.

Participants used upcycling to preserve cherished memories by transforming garments into something beautiful that has a personal history attached to it. This act of preservation demonstrates that upcycling is not merely a sustainable choice but a deeply meaningful activity that fulfils a range of psychological needs. Intrinsic motivations are considered more effective than external ones in encouraging effortful behaviours like consumer upcycling (Shi et al. 2024).

Furthermore, the act of upcycling was intrinsically linked to creative identity and empowerment. The process of transformation was described as fun and satisfying, providing a sense of accomplishment and pride. This act fuels a high level of Perceived Behavioural Control (PBC). Unlike non-upcyclers, this group's confidence in their ability to create, even if imperfectly, mitigated barriers of time or complex technicality. Their Attitude was thus shaped by the outcome and the enjoyment of the creative journey. Positive emotions, influenced by perceived utilitarian and hedonic values of fashion upcycling, can lead to increased share intention and overall well-being (ARIAH VALDERRAMA2023).

Upcyclers are critically supportive of brands taking initiatives for upcycling. They welcome the awareness that brand initiatives bring to sustainability, but are highly sceptical of the motives, constantly looking out for "greenwashing" and demanding genuine, systemic change rather than just marketing campaigns.

They have an informed perspective that values authenticity. On the other hand, brands are increasingly enthusiastic about eco-friendly approaches in textiles and fashion for their consumer, and this enhances the brand's reputation and differentiation (Ofori et al. 2025).

While practical barriers like a lack of skills were cited, the findings suggest that psychological barriers are the more hindering for non-upcyclers. The most significant concern raised by one of the participants was the "hygiene hurdle," an apprehension about the potential contamination of a garment from its unknown past. This fear frames secondhand materials not as an opportunity, but as a risk, creating a powerful negative Attitude that does not override any positive feelings about sustainability (Matthews 2024).

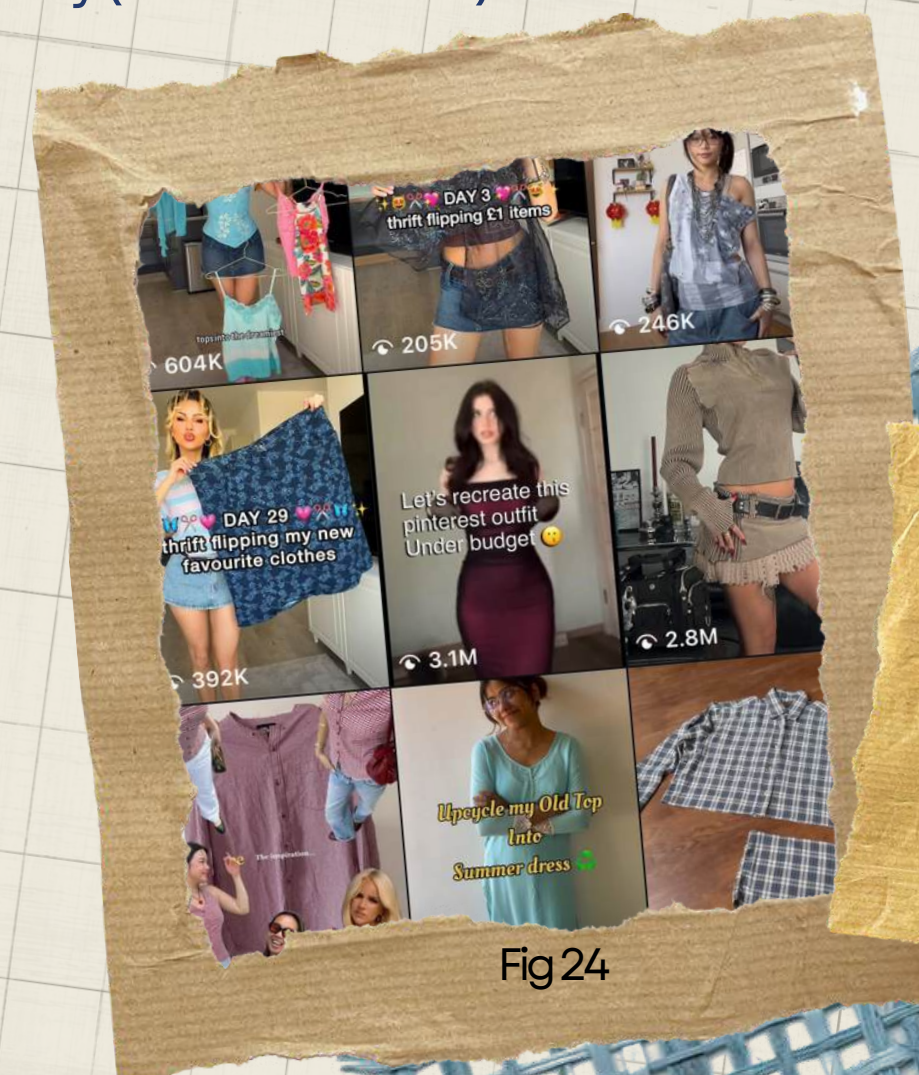


Fig 24



Fig 25

This was also backed by the fear of a negative outcome. Participants expressed apprehension that their efforts would "ruin the product," reflecting a critically low PBC regarding not just a lack of technical skill but in a profound lack of creative self-efficacy. Finally, the theme of cultural disconnect highlights how negative Subjective Norms can make upcycling an alien concept. When a culture prizes newness, as described by one of the non-upcycler participants, upcycling is not seen as a viable or desirable behaviour.

Non-upcyclers, on the other hand, are pragmatically open when it comes to their intent to upcycle through brand initiatives. These initiatives are often their first exposure to the concept, which is backed by their practical consumer perspective, so their criticality is low. They are less concerned with a brand's motives and are more influenced by convenience, clear messaging, and direct incentives like discounts.

Comparing the two cohorts reveals shared intellectual views but a dramatically different psychological and practical reality. The key distinctions lie not in whether they prioritise sustainability, but rather in their perception of their own agency and the materials involved.

Both groups acknowledged the importance of sustainability and viewed upcycling as a positive solution, confirming the prevalence of the attitude-behaviour gap within Gen Z. Both also identified social media as a powerful and inconsistent influence.

For upcyclers, it served as a catalyst for action and inspiration; for non-upcyclers, upcycling content was largely invisible, due to rampant fast fashion promotion. This critically demonstrates that while social media holds potential, its algorithm-driven nature may currently reinforce the status quo more than it challenges it.

The points of divergence between the two groups reveal a dramatically different psychological and practical reality. The most critical differentiator is Perceived Behavioural Control (PBC), where upcyclers showed a "can-do" attitude and were willing to experiment, while non-upcyclers were hindered by an apprehension that they lacked the necessary skills or creativity, suggesting PBC is the primary mediator between interest and action. But in some cases, non-upcyclers were open to the idea that they are open to the idea of getting it done through someone else. This difference in confidence is also reflected in their core Attitudes towards used garments. Upcyclers often had positive norms because of the lived experience of seeing family members repurpose clothing, which normalised the practice for them. For non-upcyclers, however, upcycling remained an abstract concept that they never witnessed in their immediate circles, making it feel like a niche activity rather than a viable option.

In conclusion, beyond surface-level issues like cost or skill, the core divide between upcyclers and non-upcyclers lies in psychology. The true obstacle to widespread adoption is not a lack of sustainable interest, but a lack of creative confidence and a cultural preference for novelty, which reflect stark contrasts with the empowerment and personal fulfilment that drive active upcyclers.

6. Limitations

Acknowledging a study's limitations is essential for ensuring academic rigour and providing a transparent account of the research context. While this study offers deep qualitative insights into the motivators and barriers to upcycling behaviours of Generation Z, its findings should be considered within the scope of its specific methodological design. The following limitations have been identified.

First, the study's findings are derived from a small, focused sample of 12 participants recruited through a purposive sampling strategy. While this approach was intentionally chosen to gain analytical depth instead of statistical breadth, it means the results are not statistically generalisable to the entire global Gen Z population. This is further complicated by the sample's cultural scope. Participants were primarily from the UK and India, despite efforts to recruit Gen Z without any demographic barriers. Only one participant out of the 12 belongs to Taiwan. The nuanced perspectives captured may not fully represent the diverse attitudes present in other cultural contexts.

Second, the research employs a cross-sectional design, providing a detailed snapshot of participants' current attitudes and practices at a single point in time. This approach has a limitation in that it cannot track the evolution of these behaviours or perceptions over time. Moreover, it cannot determine the long-term impact of influences such as social media trends or marketing campaigns.

Finally, the study relies on self-reported data collected through semi-structured interviews. While this method provides rich, personal narratives, there may be a discrepancy between what participants provide as information and their actual, unobserved behaviours. Furthermore, while reflexivity was maintained throughout the process, the researcher's own positionality as an active Gen Z participant in upcycling culture presents a potential for unconscious bias in the interpretation of data. Despite these limitations, the study offers a valuable and detailed understanding of the key psychological factors driving and hindering Gen Z to upcycling, providing a strong foundation for future research avenues recommended in the next section.



Fig 26



7. Recommendations

Fig 27

This study identifies that the primary obstacle to widespread upcycling adoption among Generation Z is not a lack of awareness about sustainability but rather a significant psychological gap. Although the intention to act sustainably exists, it is often undermined by low Perceived Behavioural Control (PBC) (a lack of confidence in creative skills) and negative Subjective Norms (cultural preferences for buying new clothing). These findings suggest that recommendations must go beyond general awareness campaigns and address certain psychological and social barriers that prevent action. The following proposals are targeted towards three key stakeholders: fashion brands and marketers, consumers, and future academic research.

For fashion brands, the priority should be to reposition upcycling from an intimidating idea into an accessible, aspirational, and mainstream practice. Brands should craft authentic and relatable brand narratives (ARIAH VALDERRAMA 2023). This study identified two key barriers for beginners: the Practicality Hurdle and the Anxiety before starting. To address these, brands could adopt “Upcycling-as-a-Service” models, where skilled professionals transform garments on behalf of customers. This removes technical barriers, improves Perceived Behavioural Control (PBC), and also allows hesitant consumers to participate in sustainable fashion without needing advanced skills. Perceived competence is the strongest internal motivation for consumer upcycling intention (Shi et al. 2024).



Fig 28

Marketing should shift from abstract sustainability jargon to emotional storytelling, where the spotlight is on a garment's history, transformation journey, and uniqueness. This generates emotional attachment among existing upcyclers and counters the "hygiene hurdle" for those wary of old or second-hand clothing. Using terms like "preloved" or "vintage" can help reframe these negative perceptions (Faludi 2025).

Community engagement is also key. Brands could host workshops, both physical and digital, to teach simple upcycling techniques in order to build skills, confidence, and reframe upcycling as a visible and normalised practice. Partnering with influencers as educators rather than mere endorsers can further shape subjective norms, making sustainable fashion not only a personal choice but also a socially reinforced one (Sung et al. 2020).

Furthermore, policymakers can play a role in encouraging a supportive ecosystem. This could include offering grants or subsidies to small-scale upcycling businesses or collaborating with brands like H&M, Patagonia, etc. to support the cause (Ofori et al. 2025). This could make people aware of the concept of upcycling.

For consumers who are interested in sustainability but hesitant to start, the focus should be on building skills and confidence gradually (Manley et al. 2023). This can begin with a small, low-stakes project. Another practical strategy is collaborating with local tailors, friends, or family members who possess sewing or design skills. This partnership approach removes the skill barrier while still allowing for personal creative input.

Finally, consumers can take control of the “Algorithm Dilemma” by following upcycling creators, sustainable fashion accounts, and DIY communities. All this can create a steady flow of inspiration and confidence, and reinforce positive behavioural norms. Social media, websites, and influencers are crucial marketing communication tools for fashion brands to engage their audience interactively (Hanadhyas, Wulandari 2022).

While this study provides rich qualitative insights into upcycling motivations and barriers among Gen Z, further research is needed to expand and deepen these findings. Future academic work could pursue three main directions:

1. Expanding scope of generalisability – To overcome the limitations of the small and culturally-specific sample, future work must include large-scale quantitative surveys. This will help establish whether the psychological factors identified here are statistically generalisable across different age groups, cultures, and economic contexts.
2. Longitudinal Studies and Observational Methods – To address the limitations of the cross-sectional design and self-reported data, longitudinal studies are needed to track how attitudes and behaviours evolve over time. Furthermore, observational or experimental research could help us know about actual upcycling behaviours, moving beyond stated intentions to provide a more accurate picture of the attitude-behaviour gap.
3. Exploring the Algorithm Dilemma – Conducting focused research on the role of social media algorithms in shaping sustainable versus unsustainable fashion consumption, informing the design of digital platforms and campaigns that nudge users towards sustainable behaviours rather than impulsive, trend-driven purchases.

Addressing the gap between sustainable intention and sustainable action requires coordinated efforts across stakeholders. Brands have the power to normalise upcycling and reduce entry barriers through service-based models, storytelling, and community engagement. Consumers can actively build skills and reshape their digital and social environments to develop sustainable habits. Further research can provide the evidence base needed to refine these interventions and ensure they are effective across diverse populations.

If implemented collectively, these recommendations could shift upcycling from a niche, craft-based activity into a mainstream practice. It would not only reduce textile waste and the environment but also empower individuals to take ownership of their fashion choices.

8. Conclusion

This research provides valuable insights into the complex motivations and barriers influencing Generation Z's participation in fashion upcycling. The key message is that the primary obstacle to widespread adoption is not a lack of sustainability awareness, but a significant psychological attitude-behaviour gap, driven primarily by low Perceived Behavioural Control (PBC) and negative Subjective Norms.

Key findings reveal a clear distinction between the two study groups. Experienced upcyclers are driven by intrinsic and emotional motivators, including creative expression, cost-saving, and a deep sentimental connection to garments. In contrast, non-upcyclers are hindered by psychological barriers, including a lack of creative confidence (the "Practicality Hurdle"), a fear of "ruining the product," and sometimes a "hygiene hurdle" associated with used materials. Social media shows a contrast, where it acts as both a source of inspiration and a driver of mass-consumption of fast fashion through the "Algorithm Dilemma".

The main contribution of this dissertation is its in-depth qualitative exploration of the post-purchase psychology of consumer upcycling, a significant gap identified in the existing literature. The broader implications of these findings extend beyond fashion, offering a model for understanding the intention-action gap in other areas of sustainable consumption or the circular economy. To build upon this work, future research should focus on quantitative research with larger, more diverse samples; longitudinal studies to track behavioural change; and a deeper investigation into the role of social media algorithms.

Ultimately, this study serves as a call to action for brands, policymakers, and consumers. The focus must shift from simply raising awareness to actively empowering individuals by helping them build skills, confidence, and a supportive community, resulting in transforming upcycling from a niche craft into a mainstream and sustainable practice.

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- Fig3: Canva, 2025d. Denim Shirt Upcycling Process.
- Fig 4: Canva, 2025c. Clothes upcycling process.
- Fig 5: Canva, 2025. Sewing Machine.
- Fig 6: Canva, 2025a. A pair of scissors.
- Fig 7: Canva, 2025a. A pair of scissors.
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- Fig 18: Canva, 2025. Cloth cutting.
- Fig 10: Canva, 2025b. Jeans repair.

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- Fig 21: Saxena, M., 2025b. Participant Upcycled denim jacket.
- Fig 22: Saxena, M., 2025c. Upcycled kurti from saree.
- Fig 23: Saxena, M., 2025d. Upcycled Skirt from Bridal dress.
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